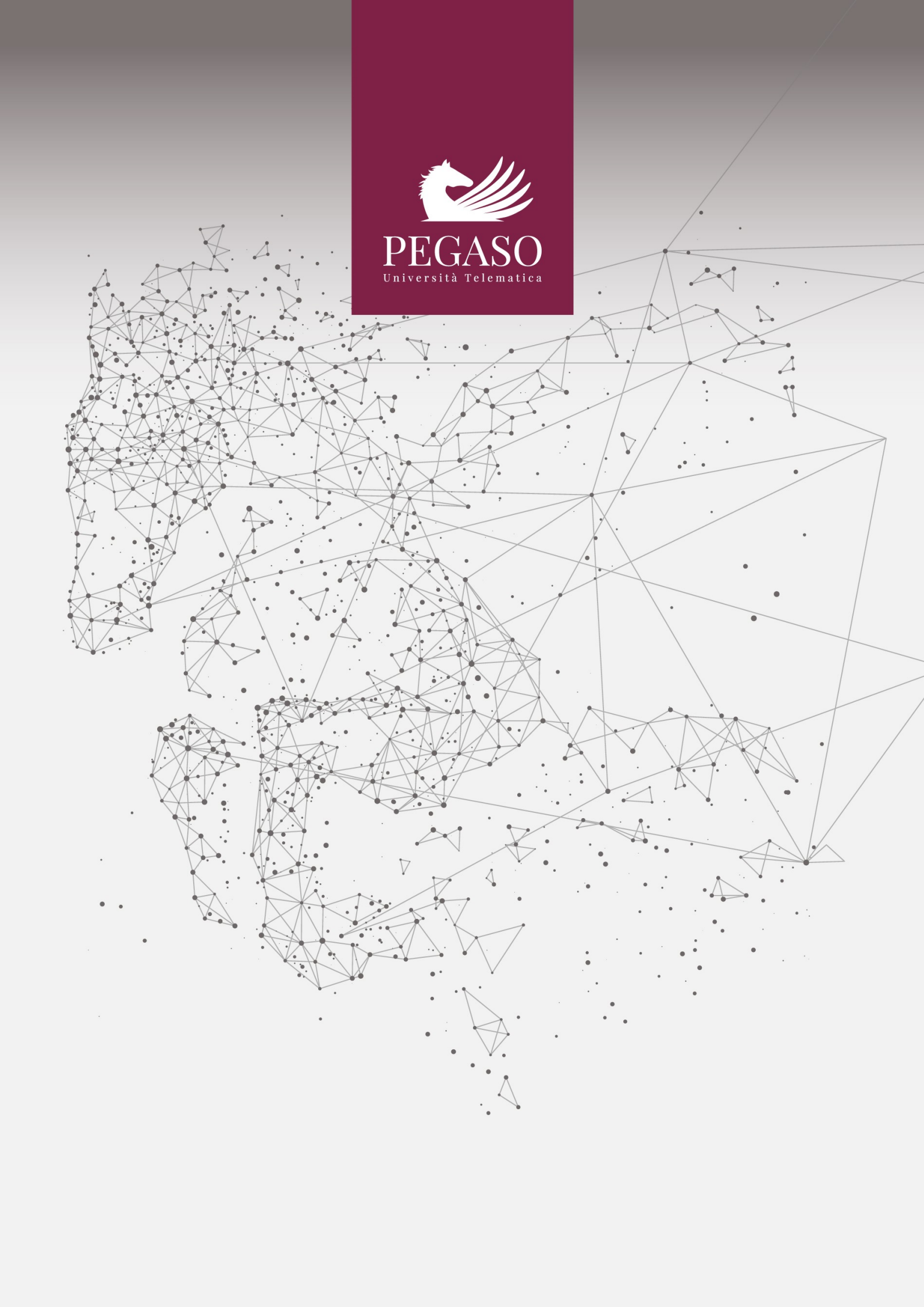

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1. Introduction to Past Modal Verbs and Phrases

A **modal** is a type of auxiliary verb (used together with an infinitive form of a main verb) that is used to express: ability, possibility, permission or obligation. **Modal phrases** (sometimes called **semi-modals**) are used to express the same ideas as proper modals, but these modal phrases are a combination of other non-modal auxiliary verbs and the preposition *to* + infinitive. Examples of **past modal verbs** and **past modal phrases** in English are: *can't/could/be able to; may/might; should/ought to/be supposed to, must/have to* + infinitive*, will/would* + infinitive, *need to/needn't, be allowed to*.

Formation of Past Modals

All modal verbs have only one form for all subjects (I, you, he/ she/ it, etc.) and to make negatives we simple add **not** to the modal and in questions we use simple inversion of the subject and modal.

Past modal verbs are followed by the **perfect infinitive** form of another non-modal main verb. The perfect infinitive = ***have + past participle***

Negative:

She can't have got lost. She grew up in this town. (***modal + not + have + past participle***)

Interrogative:

Should I have left my phone number with you? (***modal + subject + have + participle***)

Could is, in itself, considered a past modal form so the formation remains ***could + infinitive***.

I could ride a bicycle when I was only 3 years old.

The formation of past modal phrases (semi-modals) depends on the non-modal auxiliary verb used:

For ***be able to/be supposed to + infinitive*** the same rules for the verb BE in the past simple apply: ***was/were able to + infinitive*** and ***was/were supposed to + infinitive***

I wasn't supposed to hear what he said but he was talking so loudly with the door to his office open.

Were you able to see the traffic signs without your glasses?

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The same rules for all main verbs (using **did not / did** to create negatives and questions in the past) apply to: ***have to + infinitive*** and ***need to + infinitive***

I didn't have to study so hard but I wanted to impress the teacher.

Did you have to work late today?

Did she need to buy more coffee after they had guests over in the morning?

In the modal structure ***needn't + have + past participle*** is used only in the negative and therefore is formulated in this way.

The company needn't have closed all its shops in Leeds but it did anyway.

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2. Ability, Deduction, Possibility and Impossibility

Ability

We use the modal verbs ***could/couldn't + infinitive*** and the modal phrase ***was able to+ infinitive*** to talk about general past ability.

I could swim before I could walk.

I was able to talk when I was eighteen months.

Andrew's father couldn't get a job.

We tend to use the modal phrase ***was/wasn't able to + infinitive*** to talk about past ability in a specific past situation.

Fortunately, he was able to swim to the shore.

Other expressions for ability:

Did you know how to type? (***know how to + infinitive***)

He succeeded in becoming a professional footballer at eighteen. (***succeed in + gerund***)

We managed to find our way home. (***manage to + infinitive***, which suggests difficulty)

Certainty of Deduction

We use the modal verb ***must + have + past participle*** to say that we are sure about something in the past.

You must have been pleased with your exam results.

We use the modal verb ***can't + have + past participle*** in negative sentences or ***couldn't + have + past participle*** to indicate that we are sure that something was not true in the past.

It can't have been easy to win that competition. There were over 500 competitors.

She can't have gone out. Her car keys are still by the door.

He couldn't have got my message. Otherwise he would have replied by now.

Be careful: We do not use ***mustn't + have + past participle*** in this case.[1]

[1] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)

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We use the modal verbs ***might/may/could + have + past participle*** to say that we are not sure about something in the past. We think something was possibly true, but we are not certain. ***Could + have + past participle*** is also used in a similar way to ***may*** and ***might*** to say something was possible in the past and we're not sure if it happened.

He could have got lost. (= It's possible he got lost. But I don't know what happened.)

She's not here yet. She might have got stuck in traffic.

He's not answering his phone. He could have forgotten to charge it.

You could have left your bag in the shop. Shall we check there first?

We also use the negative forms ***may/might + not + have + past participle*** when we want to say we think something was possibly not true but we are not certain. In this case ***couldn't*** is not a synonym of these forms.

Possibility and Impossibility

We use ***couldn't + have + past participle*** and ***wouldn't + have + past participle*** to say that something was impossible in the past.

We couldn't have come earlier - the traffic was terrible. (= We didn't come earlier and it wasn't possible because of the traffic.)

We had a really good holiday. It couldn't have gone better.

The conference was cancelled last week. Paul wouldn't have been able to attend anyway.

We also use ***could + have + past participle*** to say that something was possible but did not happen.

You could have really hurt yourself! (= You didn't hurt yourself, but it was possible.)

Why did you stay in that hotel while you were in Paris? You could have stayed with Julia.

I didn't know you wanted to go to the concert. I could have got you a ticket.

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3. Obligation, Necessity, Prohibition and Permission

Obligation, Necessity, Prohibition

We use the modal phrase ***had to + infinitive*** to talk about past obligations (or lack of obligations) of all kinds.

I had to take my holiday in February.

Did you have to pay a lot for parking there?

They told us we didn't have to leave our bags in the cloakroom.

We had to stand up when the teacher came in.

We also use the modal phrase ***need to + infinitive*** to talk about obligation and necessity.

Did we need to type our work?

We needed to book tickets in advance.

Lack of Necessity Regarding Past Action

We use the modal phrase ***didn't need to + infinitive*** to say that something wasn't necessary without saying whether the person did it or not.

You didn't need to bring any extra money.

She didn't need to cook dinner for all of us!

We use the modal phrases **needn't + have + past participle** to express that something a person did in the past was unnecessary.

Everything was ok. You needn't have worried. (= You worried but it was not necessary.)

Paul needn't have taken his umbrella. It never rained. (= Paul took his umbrella but it was not necessary.)

Permission

To express permission or lack of permission in a past situation, we use the modal verb ***could + infinitive*** and ***couldn't + infinitive***.

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You could pay for your drinks when you left.

We could enter the ballroom by the back entrance.

You couldn't sit in this part of the restaurant.

We also use the modal phrases ***be allowed to + infinitive*** and be ***not allowed to + infinitive*** to talk about permission and prohibition.

Were you allowed to take your food outside?

You were not allowed to park there.[2]

[2] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)

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4. Past Judgment and Regret

To say that something was right or wrong or to express regret about an action done or not done in the past, we use the modal verb ***should/shouldn't + have + past participle*** and the modal phrases ***ought to + have + past participle*** and ***be supposed to + infinitive***.

Should + have + past participle to say something wasn't done but it would have been the right thing to do. This form is used to express regret or criticism even of the speaker's own actions.

I should have called you to tell you where I was. (= I didn't call you. I regret that.)

You missed a great party last night. You should have come.

She should have phoned me. (= I told her to phone me but she didn't.)

I should have called you. It was stupid of me not to.

Shouldn't + have + past participle to say something was done but it was the wrong thing to do.

I shouldn't have brought such a heavy bag on holiday. (= I brought a heavy bag. I regret it.)

I'm feeling sick. I shouldn't have eaten so much.

Ought to + have + past participle can be used instead of ***should*** in the cases mentioned above.

She ought to have applied for the job. She is such a good candidate.

They ought not to have spoken so openly about the project. It is still a confidential topic.

We can use ***be supposed to + infinitive*** when saying what someone should or should not have done something according to rules, regulations or expectations.

You were not supposed to park there. (Rule)

I was supposed to call my mum when we left the party. (Expectation)

They were not supposed to share that information with the public. (Regulation/Rule)[3]

EXERCISES

Rewrite the bold sentences using ***must / might (not)*** / ***can't + have + verb***.

Ex. I'm certain I left my umbrella at home.

I must have left my umbrella at home.

[3] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (170)

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1. Holly's crying. **Perhaps she's had an argument with her boyfriend.**

She…

2. **I'm sure Ben has read my email.** I sent it first thing this morning.

Ben…

3. **I'm sure Sam and Ginny haven't got lost.** They have satnav in their car.

They...

4. **You saw Ellie yesterday? That's impossible.** She was in bed with flu.

You…

5. **Perhaps John didn't see you.** That's why he didn't say hello.

John…

6. **I'm sure Lucy has bought a new car.** I saw her driving a blue VW Golf!

Lucy...

7. **I'm sure Alex wasn't very ill.** He was only off work for one day.

Alex…

8. They didn't go to Tom's wedding. **Maybe they weren't invited.**

They…

9. This tastes very sweet. **I'm sure you used too much sugar.**

You...

10. **It definitely wasn't my phone** that rang in the cinema. Mine was on silent.

It….

Respond to the first sentence using ***should / shouldn't have*** or ***ought / oughtn't to have + past participle*** of a verb from the list.

buy, drive, go, invite, learn, sit, take, write

Ex. A: We couldn't understand anybody in Paris.

B: You should have learned some French before going.

11. A: Tom told me the date of his party, but I've forgotten it.

B: You _____ it down.

12. A: Sorry I'm late! The traffic was terrible.

B: You _____ here. The metro is faster.

13. A: Amanda was rude to everyone at my party.

B You _____ her. You know what she's like.

14. A: I don't have any money left after going shopping.

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B: You _____ so many shoes.

15. A: You look really tired.

B: I know. I| _____ to bed earlier last night.

16 .A: The chicken's still frozen solid.

B: I know. You _____ it out of the freezer earlier.

17. A: I think I've burned my face.

B: I'm not surprised. You _____in the sun all afternoon without any sunscreen.[4]

Complete the conversation with ***could have, couldn't have, should have*** or ***shouldn't have*** and the correct form of the verbs in brackets.

A: Did you read about the woman who survived in the wild for a week after her car broke down?

B: Yes, I saw that. She was twenty kilometres from the nearest village. And she walked into the forest to find help and then got lost. I think it was a mistake to leave the car. She (18.)_____(stay) there. They (19.) _____ (find) her more quickly that way.

A: I agree. And I think she (20.)_____(leave) home without telling her friends and relatives where she was going. The article says nobody knew where she was!

B: OK, but she (21.) _____(know) her car would break down.

A: I always tell someone if I'm going on a long journey. She (22.) _____(tell) at least one person - that's obvious.

B: OK. But even then, it (23.)_____(take) a long time to find her. She was really in the middle of nowhere.

A: That's true.[5]

Translate the following text into Italian.

24. Why didn’t you wear a helmet when you went skiing? You could have hurt yourself.

25. Your report is full of mistakes. You should have checked it more carefully.

26. Somebody might have stolen your wallet when you were getting off the train.

27. She can’t have gone to work. Her car’s still here.

28. I must have left my phone at Charlie’s. I definitely remember having it there.

29. It’s my fault. I ought to have told you earlier that my party was on Saturday.

[4] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (144)
[5] H. Stephenson, J. Hughes, P. Dummett, *Life Intermediate Student Book Second Edition*, Hampshire, National Geographic Learning, 2019 (179)

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30. He still hasn't arrived. I may not have given him the right directions.

EXERCISE ANSWER KEY

1. She might have had an argument
2. Ben must have read my email
3. They can't have got lost
4. You can't have seen Ellie yesterday.
5. John might not have seen you
6. Lucy must have bought a new car.
7. They might not have been invited.
8. You must have used too much sugar full
9. It can't have been my phone
10. You should have written it down.
11. You shouldn't have driven here
12. You shouldn't have invited her.
13. You shouldn't have bought so many shoes.
14. I should have gone to bed earlier last night.
15. You should have taken it out of the freezer earlier.
16. You shouldn't have stayed in the sun all afternoon without any sunscreen.
17. She should have stayed there.
18. They could have found her more quickly that way.
19. And I think she shouldn't have left home without…
20. OK, but she couldn't have known her car…
21. She could have told at least one person…
22. But even then, it could have taken a long time…
23. Perché non hai indossato il casco quando sei andato a sciare? Avresti potuto farti male.
24. La tua relazione è piena di errori. Avresti dovuto controllarla più attentamente.
25. Qualcuno potrebbe averti rubato il portafoglio mentre scendevi dal treno.
26. Non può essere andata al lavoro. La sua auto è ancora qui.
27. Devo aver lasciato il telefono da Charlie. Ricordo perfettamente di averlo avuto lì.
29. È colpa mia. Avrei dovuto dirti prima che la mia festa era sabato.
30. Non è ancora arrivato. Potrei non avergli dato le indicazioni giuste / Forse non gli ho dato le indicazioni giuste.

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